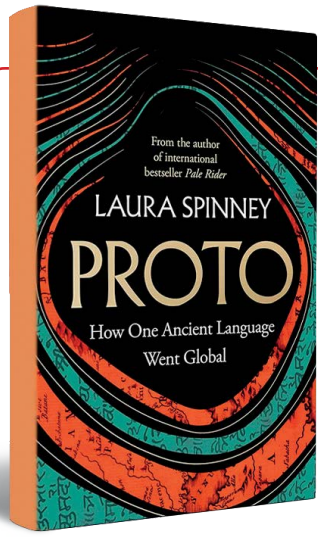
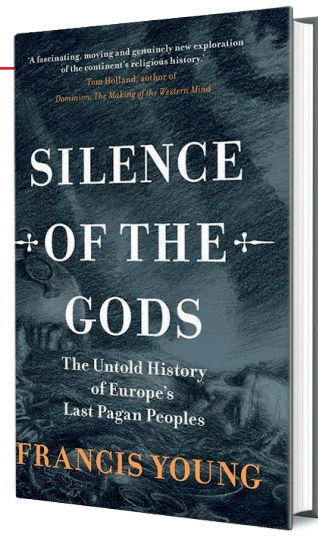


PROTO How One Ancient Language Went Global
By Laura Spinney
WILLIAM COLLINS
₹599; 352 pages



SILENCE OF THE GODS The Untold Story of Europe's Last Pagan Peoples
By Francis Young
CAMBRIDGE UNIVERSITY PRESS
£25; 432 pages

HISTORY ▼

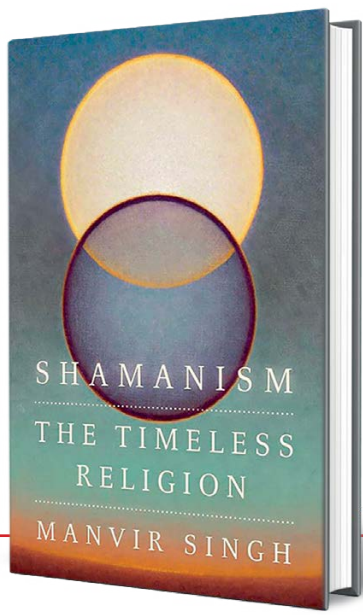
BEYOND DRY FACTS

Podcaster and geneticist **Razib Khan** picks four recent books on ancient cultures

Manvir Singh's *Shamanism* is arguably the most ambitious of the four books here because it tries to explain a pattern that appears across many, even all, societies. The narrative is a blend of anthropology, history, archaeology, and even reportage, drawing on Singh's fieldwork, all presented as a serious attempt to answer why shaman-like figures keep emerging across all cultures. After all, as we read in *Silence of the Gods* too, the old gods and shamans of the Estonians were there for them when the night was more than 18 hours long in the midst of winter; the preachers of Christianity, a religion of a desert god far to the south, offered little.

> What all four share is a focus on the **history of people, their practices and their folkways**, not the dry recitation of facts

SHAMANISM The Timeless Religion
By Manvir Singh
PENGUIN/KNOPF
$30; 304 pages



identity. *Proto* hints at the toxicity that has been associated with the 'Indo-European question', but moves the reader over and over back to the scientific issues at hand and the latest results. Less emotion. More analysis.

Francis Young's *Silence of the Gods* tackles a very different subject, the long twilight of paganism in Europe, and the late conversion of some of the continent's peoples. But, like *Proto*, the project is to probe beneath the surface of what we know and expose deeper threads. The book argues that "Europe's last pagan peoples" persisted later than most assume based on simple histories, especially in the Baltic. The story in *Silence of the Gods* looks less like an abrupt shift to silence and more like a gradual fading out of the old voices.

Moving beyond ancient rituals that linger into the present, J.P. Mallory's *The Indo-Europeans Rediscovered* is an eminent scholar's attempt to stab back into the dark prehistoric path more than 40 years after his initial foray into the topic. His book is much more focused on the intellectual history of the past than *Proto*, with its relative presentism. The point is not to hand you a satisfying ancestral epic; it is to show you what the evidence can and cannot bear, and how easily we overfit a story to the scraps we have.

Despite differences of place and time, human experience seems quite universal. The challenge of the modern world is the same as the ancient: we face real uncertainties, but we also face political, cultural and digital systems that profit from keeping us perpetually scanning for the next catastrophe, or the next ancestor, or the next god. ■